

In one line: The cheapest byte is the one **never sent**. Work down the ladder: **don't send** (cache, 304), **send less** (fields, pages, deltas), **encode smaller** (binary, no names), **compress** (brotli / zstd / gzip), **right-size media** (pixels you display, modern formats), and **adapt** to the link (HLS). On mobile, fewer *requests* matter as much as fewer bytes: every one costs RTTs and radio time.

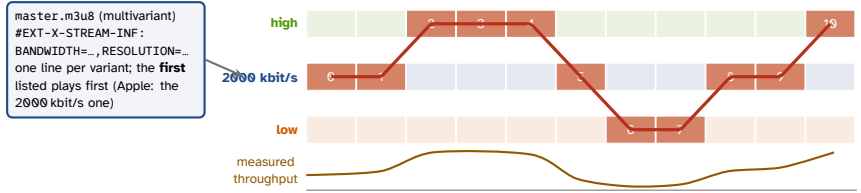
The lever ladder — try the top first

- 1 **Don't send:** fresh cache, ETag → 304
- 2 **Send less:** fields, pages, deltas
- 3 **Encode smaller:** binary, short keys
- 4 **Compress:** br / zstd / gzip (text)
- 5 **Right-size media:** px, AVIF/HEIC
- 6 **Adapt:** ABR ladder (HLS), prefetch

Each rung multiplies the next: a cached response needs no compression; a right-sized image needs no ABR.

bigger win → smaller win

HLS adaptive bitrate — the player picks a variant per segment



Segments: target duration 6 s, IDR every 2 s (Apple authoring spec) — switches happen at segment boundaries. Arithmetic: a 6 s segment at 2000 kbit/s = 12 Mbit = 1.5 MB; on a 1 Mbit/s link it takes 12 s to fetch 6 s of video → the buffer drains → step down. LL-HLS: parts ≈ 1 s (at least the P95 RTT).

Compression

- **gzip** (DEFLATE + 10-byte header + 8-byte CRC/size trailer, RFC 1952): everywhere. **Brotli** (br, RFC 7932): built-in static dictionary of web text — best on text, slow at max level (pre-compress static assets). **zstd** (RFC 8878): fast, trainable dictionaries.
- **Negotiation:** Accept-Encoding → Content-Encoding + Vary: Accept-Encoding. URLSession decodes gzip, deflate, br itself; zstd came to the *system networking stack* in iOS 26.3 (WebKit, for Safari) — log your app's Accept-Encoding before relying on it.
- **Request bodies are never compressed for you:** compress, set Content-Encoding, and make sure the server accepts it. Apple's Compression offers zlib, LZFS, LZ4, LZMA, brotli — COMPRESSION_ZLIB is **raw DEFLATE** (no gzip/zlib header).
- Skip already-compressed data (JPEG, HEIC, MP4, zip) and tiny bodies (framing > saving).

Send less, encode smaller

- **Field selection:** ?fields=id,name,sparse fieldsets, or GraphQL — list endpoints return *summaries*, detail endpoints the rest.
- **Pagination:** cursor-based (after=<opaque>), stable under inserts) beats offset; page size tuned to one screen + a prefetch margin.
- **Delta sync:** since=<syncToken> returns only changes + tombstones; edits as PATCH with JSON Merge Patch (RFC 7396) or JSON Patch (RFC 6902).
- **Binary:** one record is 54 B as JSON, **16 B** as protobuf (no names, no text digits); gzip narrows the gap on big payloads only.
- **Batching:** many small writes in one request (analytics, receipts) — fewer radio wakes, fewer server round trips. HTTP/2 makes requests cheap, not free.

Example — right-sized image + measuring the wire

```
let px = Int(side * traitCollection.displayScale) // 100 pt @3x = 300 px
var c = URLComponents(string: "https://img.example.com/p/42")!
c.queryItems = [URLQueryItem(name: "w", value: "\\(px)")] // CDN resizes
var req = URLRequest(url: c.url!)
req.setValue("image/avif,image/webp,image/*;q=0.8",
             forHTTPHeaderField: "Accept") // CDN negotiates + Vary: Accept

// URLSessionTaskDelegate, didFinishCollecting metrics:
let t = metrics.transactionMetrics.last!
let wire = t.countOfResponseBodyBytesReceived // compressed
let body = t.countOfResponseBodyBytesAfterDecoding // after br/gzip
log("ratio", Double(body) / Double(max(wire, 1)))
```

Related: http-deep (caching, Vary) · grpc-protobuf · graphql-apollo (field selection) · rendering-pipeline (image decode) · app-size-and-energy · poor-network-engineering

Images and media

format	Apple support	use
JPEG / PNG	always	baseline; PNG for flat art / alpha
HEIC	camera, iOS 11+	device photos; convert for web / Android
WebP	Safari 14 / iOS 14	web images, alpha, animation
AVIF	Safari 16 / iOS 16	smallest photos; slow to encode
JPEG XL	Safari 17 / iOS 17	lossless re-pack of existing JPEGs

Size by pixels: request *points* × *scale*; a CDN resizes + converts on the fly. Tiny placeholder / progressive JPEG first. Video: HLS; cap on cellular with AVPlayerItem.preferredPeakBitRate / preferredMaximumResolution. AVPlayer plays HLS, not MPEG-DASH (*unverified*) (the ISO equivalent used on Android/web).

Transfer time = RTTs + bytes / bandwidth

payload (1 KB = 1000 B)	1 Mbit/s	10 Mbit/s	100 Mbit/s
50 KB JSON page	0.4 s	40 ms	4 ms
500 KB photo	4 s	0.4 s	40 ms
1.5 MB 6 s HLS segment	12 s	1.2 s	0.12 s
5 MB unsized hero image	40 s	4 s	0.4 s

Pure serialisation, before RTTs and slow start. At 100 Mbit/s a 50 KB page is RTT-bound — so batch and reuse connections; at 1 Mbit/s bytes dominate — so shrink.

Prefetch and cache

Prefetch the *next* page while the radio is up (UICollectionViewDataSourcePrefetching, cancel in cancelPrefetchingForItemsAt). Hashed URLs + immutable; the rest ETag → 304. Low Data Mode: no prefetch, lower variants.

Traps

- ! Downloading a 4000-px photo for a 100-pt cell: bytes, decode time and memory all wasted.
- ! "HTTP/2 made batching pointless" — headers are cheap now; radio wakes and server work are not.
- ! Gzipping a request with COMPRESSION_ZLIB and labelling it gzip — it is raw DEFLATE.

Remember

"Don't send, send less, encode small, compress, size to pixels, adapt."